

19, Warlord Chaos and Barbarian Invasions During the Collapse of Classical Empires

Now, let us return to the generalized historical trajectory: what profound societal mutations occur as a **classical empire** marches toward disintegration?

During the empire's terminal phase, the phenomenon of rule by **Warlords** (军阀) becomes glaringly prominent. Certain exceptionally powerful warlords might manage to restore a fleeting illusion of peace and unification following the initial chaos, but this is inevitably followed by the absolute, total collapse of the state!

The only potential paradox here is that these historical warlords have suffered phenomenally "unjust" evaluations! Contemporary observers across the globe, invariably clouded by an excessive, romanticized nostalgia for the towering majesty (重冈俊阜) of classical empires, obsessively condemn these warlords as the annihilators of civilization, demanding they bear the ultimate responsibility for the termination of the **classical period**. **This is profoundly absurd!**

It is glaringly obvious that the true culprit was the aggressive development of **feudal** land relations! The **landlord class** systematically annexed land and expanded their manors (庄园); the **natural economy** (自然经济) increasingly suffocated the empire; and the imperial state systematically lost control over the provinces financially, militarily, and administratively. **This was absolutely not caused by warlords!**

On the contrary, it was those exceptional military leaders—who had long commanded forces on the empire's frontiers—who leveraged potent military machines fiercely loyal to themselves to artificially resuscitate the empire for a few extra moments! In that exceedingly brief window, frontier warlords monopolized two colossal advantages: they reaped the accumulated fruits of the classical empire's military infrastructure, while simultaneously exploiting the **feudalization** process to transform their armies into private retinues (军队部曲化 / *buqu*).

During an epoch when social organization was undergoing apocalyptic disintegration, the army—relying on its intrinsic disciplinary machinery—inevitably mutated into the most highly organized social entity remaining! Many warlords hailed from humble origins and possessed zero traditional identitarian recognition that could bestow higher social status upon them. For an imperial government increasingly impotent to control its territories, these warlords and their armed forces constituted the absolute last resort to maintain the empire's vital functions, such as tax collection!

Therefore, in the overwhelming majority of cases, the warlords of **Late Antiquity** (古典时代晚期) and the empire were mutually parasitical! The warlords undeniably secured supreme orthodox legitimacy (大义名分) and astronomical power through this symbiosis. However, without the scaffolding provided by the warlords, the empire (*referring to the imperial system itself, not merely a specific dynasty*) would have disintegrated infinitely faster!

As for the blood-soaked civil wars between warlords, it is even more preposterous to dump the blame squarely on their heads. **It was not warlord chaos that caused the collapse of social order; it was the collapse of social order that birthed warlord chaos!** War was inevitable—after all, one could hardly expect competing military dictators to settle supremacy by playing rock-paper-scissors!

The contemporary narrative obsessively claiming that warlord chaos brought about the "destruction of social production" is also grotesquely exaggerated! This occurs simply because far too many

people forcibly attribute the organic, inevitable consequences of the **feudalization** process to the warlords! If one is familiar with the generalized historical evaluations of the rulers during the Wei and Jin (魏晋) dynasties in China, this fallacy becomes glaringly obvious. The decay of the **commodity economy** (商品经济), the collapse of urban centers, and even the regression of craftsmanship are inexplicably, universally blamed on the warlords! **Yet, it is glaringly evident that these are the absolute, deterministic phenomena of feudalization!** Individual military dictators fundamentally lacked the capacity to significantly alter this trajectory.

Although military dictators could temporarily expand their tax base and consolidate rule through mechanisms like the *Tuntian* (屯田 / military agricultural colonies) system, they could never ultimately obstruct the juggernaut of **feudalization**. The unification of the empire was doomed to be unsustainable!

During the 3rd and 4th centuries in Rome, from the mid-9th century onward in the Arab Empire, following the collapse of the Gupta Dynasty in India, and during the late Han, Wei, and Jin periods in China—the phenomenon of military dictators actively dominating the political stage during the terminal phase of classical empires universally erupted! Even during the late Heian period in Japan, it is highly likely people found it exceedingly difficult to distinguish explicitly between the *Samurai* (武士) and warlords of that era.

The rise of warlords in Late Antiquity is an intrinsic component of the universal historical progression; one cannot absurdly claim that warlords clutching military power "murdered" the empire!

Following the warlord chaos, the most pivotal participant in the **feudalization** process materialized: **the Barbarians (蛮族) on the frontiers.**

The barbarians suffer from even more unprovoked infamy and historical vilification than the warlords! And in my view, they might be even more innocent. The military men on the empire's frontiers were, at least nominally, subjects of the empire. However, regarding the barbarians lurking beyond the borders: it was invariably the empire's armies that had proactively intruded into their domains decades prior—and absolutely not with peaceful or diplomatic intentions! This is a profoundly crucial reality to acknowledge.

The fundamental reason the barbarians on the empire's frontiers could phenomenally elevate their societal developmental stage in such a compressed timeframe—reaching the point where they organically generated a demand for **feudalization**—was, to a massive extent, **the direct consequence of the classical empire's own hyper-expansion!**

This was particularly true for the Han and Roman empires—two regimes that commanded terrifyingly formidable **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) during their transitional phases. Their military presence frequently and vastly overextended far beyond the territories they could actually govern! Consequently, in the borderlands, or in military buffer zones extending beyond the borders, the indigenous populations were subjected to the overwhelming radiation of classical civilization, experiencing a meteoric elevation in their productive forces and civilizational levels.

After imperial prestige was projected across all directions (国威布于四方), a cohort of barbarian regimes swearing fealty to the empire inevitably emerged along the frontiers. To slash the

astronomical costs of warfare, classical empires naturally leveraged their terrifying aura, status, and wealth to conscript these subjugated chieftains and kingdoms as auxiliary forces (仆从军).

This marked the first step in the system created by the barbarians entering the empire with a legal identity! And this step would be rapidly bypassed, simply because the empire was undergoing **feudalization**! New manors were monopolizing massive demographics, and the empire's former "citizen armies" (公民军队) were evaporating!

Confronted with this fatal mutation, besides increasingly pivoting toward mercenary systems (募兵制) and military professionalization, classical empires universally and inevitably discovered a third "excellent solution": **absorbing barbarians directly into the imperial army!** During Late Antiquity, when the monarch's power was already violently trembling on the brink of collapse, barbarian generals serving the empire stepped onto the historical stage. At the very least, these barbarian generals appeared to lack deep political roots within the empire, nor did they possess the necessary orthodox legitimacy (名分) to usurp the throne!

As the empire grows increasingly decrepit, beyond the civilized "barbarians" who have long interacted with and aligned themselves with the empire, menacing "*raw savages*" (生番 / a Sinicized derogatory term denoting barbarians utterly ignorant of civilization) begin to emerge from the distant horizons.

At this juncture, the empire has lost both the administrative and financial capacity to control its formerly vast frontiers. Therefore, permitting the relatively civilized barbarians—those familiar to and obedient to the empire—to enter the borderlands and serve as a defensive buffer (藩屏) becomes a phenomenally natural phenomenon!

Furthermore, the virulent land annexation movement sweeping the nation driven by **feudalization** systematically liquidates small landholders across the empire. A crucial mechanism for massive landlords to replenish their manorial labor force is directly importing barbarians from the frontiers to serve as slaves or tenant farmers (佃客)! This fiercely accelerated the mass migration of barbarians into the imperial hinterland—a phenomenon that became catastrophically conspicuous during the Western Jin Dynasty in our nation.

During the warlord chaos marking the empire's terminal phase, barbarians were frantically recruited as external reinforcements by all warring factions. Various ethnic groups relentlessly plunged deeper into the imperial heartland. This astronomically elevated the status of barbarian chieftains, allowing these previously despised, "backward" peoples to intimately and deeply participate in what was once world-renowned high politics!

When the warring factions of the empire had bled each other dry and the empire's absolute authority had utterly evaporated, the barbarian rulers suddenly realized they no longer needed to submit to anyone! They would forge an era of their own!

The unvarnished truth is: regarding the entire process of barbarians "Entering the Pass" (入关) during the late feudalization period, it is phenomenally difficult to legitimately blame the barbarians! First, the empire hyper-expanded its borders right to the barbarians' doorsteps. Then, the empire's rulers proactively invited the barbarians into the borderlands. Finally, the usurpers vying for imperial power violently shoved the barbarians onto the historical center stage!

Yet, this authentic historical progression—which irrefutably occurred on both ends of the Eurasian landmass—is routinely and falsely depicted as a narrative of bloodthirsty barbarians utilizing sheer violence to ravage civilized lands, committing unspeakable atrocities of rape and pillage! It is glaringly obvious that virtually no one genuinely cares *why* classical empires meet their demise; the overwhelming majority merely desire to hunt down a scapegoat and point a condemning finger at a convenient murderer!

The classical empires of China and Rome collapsed relatively early, enabling them to complete this evolutionary trajectory largely devoid of massive external interference. However, for India and Persia—two civilizations whose typical **classical periods** arrived significantly later—they were inexorably forced to confront the apocalyptic shockwaves triggered by the political deaths of China and Rome (including the **late-classical empire** of Byzantium here), specifically the terrifying wave of the "Great Migration of Peoples" crashing across the Eurasian landmass!

Yet, as history explicitly demonstrates: although India and Persia identically faced barbarians amassing on their frontiers (*as a reminder: "barbarians" here merely denotes aliens to the imperial rulers, not necessarily "savages"; e.g., the Greeks and Hellenistic states appearing in northwestern India could hardly be deemed more backward than India*), because the Gupta Dynasty and the Sasanian Empire were at the absolute zenith of their **classical empires**, these invaders—despite inflicting monumental havoc—were fundamentally incapable of subverting the empires!

On the contrary, from the 3rd to the 6th century, several formidable ethnic groups attempting to assault the Iranian and Indian empires between these two realms were utterly crushed! The most iconic examples are the Indo-Scythians (印度—斯基泰人), who were ultimately annihilated by the Gupta Dynasty at its zenith (*under the rule of Chandragupta II / 旃陀罗笈多二世*), and the Hephthalites (嚙哒人), who were pulverized by the Sasanian Dynasty at its zenith (*under Khosrau I*).

And this was achieved despite the terrifying reality that the technological advantages possessed by the Iranians and Indians over these frontier invaders were phenomenally smaller than the staggering technological supremacy once commanded by the Han Chinese and Romans! It was not until the **feudalization** of Northern India became glaringly pronounced, and the Gupta Dynasty began to disintegrate from within, that the *Huna* (匈奴人) finally shattered this colossal empire! **But even then, they failed to fundamentally "Enter the Pass"!** (*It is not that no one entered the pass; retroactively, the Rajputs were the successful invaders. But due to India's labyrinthine geopolitical landscape, other formidable forces still existed*).

These historical realities are overwhelmingly sufficient to prove that for frontier barbarians, defeating a classical empire at its zenith is phenomenally close to impossible! Imperial rulers possessed the terrifying clarity to mount swift, devastating responses, and would absolutely never commit suicidal acts resembling the "inviting wolves into the house" (引狼入室) blunders seen in late empires.

The Khmer Empire (高棉帝国), acting as the absolute final **classical empire** (*chronologically, it might not have been the absolute last, but in terms of relatively completely experiencing the entire evolutionary cycle, it undeniably was; shortly after the Khmer Empire fell, European expansion forcibly integrated the entire globe, ensuring no region could ever again complete the evolutionary process independently*), offers identical evidence through the stone reliefs of Angkor, despite the

agonizing scarcity of written records. In the Khmer people's final glorious epoch in the early 13th century, the figures of Thai soldiers materialized in warfare bas-reliefs; they were highly likely fighting for the empire as mercenaries.

Far more tragically than the Persians and Indians, the "barbarians" the Khmer were forced to confront—the Burmese, the Thais, and even the Vietnamese, who relentlessly encroached from north to south under the overwhelming gravitational pull of China—were actually the technologically and organizationally *superior* side relative to the Khmer! Their population ratios were also staggeringly massive!

The Khmer Empire could barely suppress these interlopers in the 12th century. But by the late 13th century, when the Yuan Dynasty Chinese diplomat Zhou Daguan (周达观) visited Angkor, the empire was already violently teetering on the brink of collapse!

However, what is genuinely astonishing is this: although one might argue that modern Cambodia is phenomenally smaller than the Khmer Empire at its zenith, the core heartland of this empire was miraculously preserved entirely! (*Even if only the core remained; the most catastrophic loss was undeniably the Mekong Delta, known as "Lower Khmer" [下高棉]*). This definitively proves that even under apocalyptic circumstances, the Khmer people still executed certain monumentally correct decisions, which will be addressed later.

Naturally, one must equally not overlook the highly specific geographical realities of the Indochinese Peninsula (中南半岛). The hyper-dense tropical rainforests inevitably constituted a brutal obstacle to conquest during the empire's expansion phase; but when the empire plunged into decline, the barbarians attempting to conquer the empire were severely obstructed by those exact same forests!

19, 古典帝国崩溃时的军阀混战和蛮族入侵

现在回到一般的历史进程上来，看一看古典帝国在走向瓦解的时候社会会发生什么变化？在帝国的最后阶段，军阀（warlord）统治的现象会变得极为显著，个别强大的军阀或许能够在最初的混乱后恢复昙花一现的和平与统一，紧接着国家就会彻底崩溃。这里唯一可能出现的疑问是当年的军阀们遭到了“不公正”的评价，现在全世界各国稀里糊涂的观察者们总是出于对古典帝国崇冈俊阜的过分怀念，指责军阀们是文明的毁灭者，应当对古典时期的终结负有责任，这就过于奇怪了。明明是随着封建土地关系的发展，地主阶级逐渐兼并土地扩大庄园，自然经济在帝国内境越来越占上风，帝国从财政、军事和行政上都在失去对地方的控制，这显然不是军阀造成的。相反，那些在帝国边境长期率领军队的杰出领袖凭借一支强有力的，对其个人效忠的军事力量在最后时刻让给帝国多续了一条命。在很短的时期内，边境武人同时占据两个优势，他们既享受到了古典帝国军事建设的成果，也利用封建化的过程将军队部曲化。在社会组织全面瓦解的时期，军队以其惯有的纪律性很难不成为组织力量最强的社会团体。很多军阀出身不高，没有什么传统的认同能赋予他们更高的社会地位，对于愈发无法控制各地的帝国政府来说，军阀及其武装是维持帝国必要的运转，例如税收，最后能够依靠的力量了。

因此大部分情况下，古典时代晚期的军阀和帝国都在互相利用，军阀确实因此获得了大义名分和更大的权力，但是如果没有军阀的支撑，帝国（帝国体制，并非指某一王朝）只能灭亡得更快。至于军阀之间的混战那更是难以算到军阀们头上，不是因为军阀混战社会秩序才瓦解，而是因为社会秩序瓦解才会军阀混战。战争难以避免，毕竟谁都不可能指望各个军事统治者通过划拳的方式决出胜者。现在人们所说的军阀混战带来“社会生产的破坏”也常常被夸大，因为太多人把封建化进程的自然后果算到军阀们头上了，如果人们熟悉国内魏晋统治者一般的评价就不难注意到这一点。什么商品经济衰退，城市衰退甚至工艺技术的退步居然全都能算到军阀的头上，但很显然这些都是封建化的必然现象，个别军事统治者根本对其难以造成多少影响。军事统治者虽然可以在短期内通过屯田这样的方式扩大税基巩固其统治，不过最终也无法阻挡封建化的进程，帝国的统一是不可能维持下去的。在三、四世纪的罗马，九世

纪中叶以来的阿拉伯帝国，笈多王朝结束之后的印度以及汉末魏晋时期的中国都发生了古典帝国终结时期军事统治者在政治舞台上十分活跃的现象。即使是平安时代末期的日本，人们恐怕也很难把当年的武士和军阀明显区分开。古典帝国晚期军阀崛起的现象是普遍历史进程的一部分，不能说是拥兵自重的军阀“谋杀”了帝国。

在军阀混战之后，封建化进程的最重要的一个参与方出现了，那就是边境的蛮族。蛮族平白无故蒙受的骂名比军阀还要多，而且在我看来它可能要更无辜一些，帝国边疆的武人至少名义上是帝国的臣子，但是对于帝国边境的蛮族而言，往往是若干年前帝国的军队主动来到了他们活动的范围，而且不会是以和平友好的方式到来，这是十分值得注意的。帝国边境地区的蛮族之所以会在很短的时间里将其社会发展水平提高到产生了封建化需求这个地步，很大程度上就是古典帝国过度扩张的结果。尤其是对于汉帝国和罗马这两个在过渡时期基础性权力特别强的政权，其军事存在在一段时期内远远越过了它能够统治的领土。因此在帝国的边境地区，或者已经离开边境的军事警戒地区，这里的原住民会受到古典文明的强烈影响，在生产力和文明水平上迅速提升。在国威布于四方之后，帝国的边境上出现了一批对于帝国效忠的蛮族政权，为了减少战争的成本，古典帝国当然会利用自己的威势、地位和财富驱使这些服从的酋长和王国在战争中作为仆从军。这是蛮族以合法身份进入帝国所创造的体系的第一步，而且这一步会很快跨过去，因为帝国正在封建化，新的庄园占有了大量人口，帝国曾经的“公民军队”正在消失。面对这种变化，帝国在越来越倾向于募兵制和军队职业化以外，无一没有发现第三个好办法，那就是把蛮族吸纳进入军队。在古典帝国晚期君主权力已经摇摇欲坠的时候，为帝国服务的蛮族军事将领也登上了历史舞台，至少蛮族将领看起来在帝国缺少根基，也没有那么多篡权夺位的名分。

随着帝国越来越衰弱，在那些和帝国常年交往的亲近帝国的蛮族以外，更远的地方又出现了具有威胁的“生番”（这是中国化的说法，用以贬低那些对文明一无所知的蛮族）。现在帝国已经既无行政力量，也无财政力量控制原先广大的边境，那么至少允许帝国了解的，比较文明的，服从于帝国的蛮族进入帝国的边境地区作为藩屏就非常自然。除此之外，因为封建化而席卷全国的土地兼并运动将使得帝国内的小地产者基本消亡，大地主补充庄园劳动力的一个重要手段就是引入边境地区的蛮族将其作为奴隶或者佃客，这进一步促进了蛮族向帝国内运动，该现象在我国西晋时期已经变得极其显著。在帝国结束时期的军阀混战中，蛮族被参与各方纷纷引为外援，各民族继续向帝国腹地运动，这增强了蛮族领袖的地位并使这些曾经被鄙夷的落后民族深度参与到原先闻名世界的政治中去。当帝国混战的各方都已经打到山穷水尽，帝国的权威一点都不复存在的时候，蛮族统治者就会发现自己不再需要臣属于任何人，他们要开创属于自己的时代。事实就是，对于封建化晚期蛮族入关的整个过程人们很难去怪罪蛮族，一开始是帝国把边境扩张到这些蛮族的家门口，接着又是帝国的统治者把蛮族请入帝国的边疆，最后是帝国权力的争夺者们把蛮族推向历史的舞台。这样真实的，在欧亚大陆两端都无可争议地发生的历史进程，却时常被解释为穷凶极恶的蛮族用武力侵犯了文明的土地，烧杀抢掠无恶不作。很显然，根本没有几个人在意古典帝国为什么走向结束这个问题，大部分人都只是想找一个替罪羊和可以谴责的凶手罢了。

中国和罗马的古典帝国崩溃得比较早，这使得它们在没有外部明显干扰的情况下完成了这段演化进程，但是在印度和波斯这两个典型古典时期都比较晚的文明，它们就不得不遇到中国和罗马这两个先行走完了古典时期生命历程的政权（这里就算拜占庭这个晚期古典帝国了）所引起的后果，这就包括整个欧亚大陆出现的民族大迁徙浪潮。但是正如历史所显示的，尽管印度和波斯一样要面对出现在边境的蛮族（再提醒一下，这里的蛮族是指对于帝国统治者来说的异类，也不是一定要多么野蛮，比如出现在印度西北部的希腊人和希腊化国家，那就没人能说这些群体比印度更落后），但是因为笈多王朝和萨珊帝国处在古典帝国的鼎盛时期，这些入侵者即使造成了相当大的麻烦，但是却不足以将帝国颠覆掉。与之相反，从三世纪到六世纪，一些出现在伊朗帝国和印度帝国之间试图进攻这两个帝国的强大民族都被击溃了，具有代表性的是被笈多王朝在鼎盛时期（旃陀罗笈多二世 Chandragupta 2 统治）最终摧毁的印度—斯基泰人（Indo-Scythians）以及被萨珊王朝在鼎盛时期（库斯劳一世）击溃的嚙哒人

（Hephthalites）。这还是伊朗人和印度人面临这些边境入侵者所拥有的技术优势远远小于当年汉人和罗马人所拥有的技术优势的情况下实现的。直到北印度的封建化十分明显，笈多王朝已经开始从内部瓦解的时候，匈奴人才击溃了这个大帝国，但即使如此也没有完成入关。（并不是没有人入关，在当年看来拉杰普特人就是成功入关者，但是因为印度的局势复杂，尚有其他强大势力存在）

这些事实足以表明边疆蛮族想要击败鼎盛时期的古典帝国是极为困难的，帝国统治者能够以清晰的认识做出迅速有力的回应，至少不会干出帝国晚期那样看起来像“引狼入室”一样的行为。高棉帝国作

为最后一个古典帝国（从时间上看不一定是最后一个，但是从相对完整经历整个演化阶段来说的确是了，高棉帝国覆灭后不久，欧洲人就将其存在扩大到了全世界，再也没有一个地方能够相对独立地完成整个演化进程）虽然记载十分稀少，不过吴哥的浮雕给出了相同的证据。在 13 世纪初高棉人最后的辉煌年代，泰人士兵的形象出现在了战争浮雕中，它们或许在当时作为雇佣兵为帝国作战。比波斯人和印度人更为悲剧的是，高棉人所要面临的这些“蛮族”，在中国的影响下从北向南步步逼近的缅人、泰人甚至是越南人相对于高棉甚至在技术和组织上都属于先进的一方，人数按比例来算也庞大到惊人。高棉帝国在 12 世纪还可以勉强压制住这些外来者，但是等到 13 世纪末我国元代外交官周达观访问吴哥时，这个帝国就已经摇摇欲坠了。不过令人惊奇的是，人们或许会说今天的柬埔寨比起高棉帝国的鼎盛时期小了太多太多，但是这个帝国的核心区域居然几乎都留了下来，虽然也就只剩核心区域了（最严重的损失莫过于丢掉了作为“下高棉”的湄公河三角洲）。这说明高棉人即使在悲惨的形势下依然做出了某些正确的决定，这一点在之后会提到。当然人们也不能忽视中南半岛特有的地理情况，茂密的森林在帝国扩张的时候会成为征服的障碍，但是当帝国走向衰落的时候，征服帝国的蛮族同样会被其阻碍。